Saviours AI

ICSE CLASS 10 · 2027 SYLLABUS

SIDE KICK

Julius Caesar

Acts III, IV and V scene by scene: summaries, key speeches, quotes, glossaries, context questions and HOT questions.



EVERY TOPPER HAS A SIDEKICK

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Hey. I'm your Sidekick.

I live inside this book. Wherever things get tricky, I pop up with a tip, a trap to dodge, or a question the board loves to ask. Read the chapter, then try my HOT questions. Deal?



Aligned to the official ICSE 2027 syllabus. If it's in the syllabus, it's in here.

SIDEKICK TIP
Shortcuts, mnemonics and exam hacks.

FUN FACT
Things that make the concept stick.

REAL LIFE
Where this shows up outside the exam hall.

KEY POINT
Definitions and laws you must write exactly.

HOT QUESTION
Higher-order thinking. Try before you peek.

✦ NEW
Added in this edition to match the 2027 syllabus.

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01

CHAPTER · JULIUS CAESAR

The Story So Far: Acts I and II

Your syllabus text starts at Act III, but the exam assumes you know how the plot got there. Here is the whole set-up in a few minutes of reading.



IN THIS CHAPTER

- Rome in 44 BC
- Cassius recruits Brutus
- Omens
- The conspiracy
- Portia and Calpurnia

Rome at the Start

Julius Caesar has just beaten his rival Pompey's sons in a civil war and returned to Rome as its most powerful man. Ordinary citizens are celebrating the feast of Lupercal. Two tribunes, Flavius and Marullus, scold the crowd for cheering the man who defeated Pompey, and are later 'put to silence' for pulling decorations off Caesar's statues. The mood of the city is split: love for Caesar on one side, fear of a king on the other.

Act I: A Seed Is Planted

- A **soothsayer** calls out to Caesar in the crowd: 'Beware the ides of March.' Caesar dismisses him as 'a dreamer'.
- **Cassius** sounds out **Brutus**. He plays on Brutus' love of Rome and his sense of honour, saying that Caesar 'doth bestride the narrow world like a Colossus' while smaller men creep about beneath him.
- Offstage, Antony offers Caesar a crown three times. Caesar refuses it each time, but **Casca** reports that he did so reluctantly, and that Caesar then collapsed in a fit (he is epileptic).
- Caesar tells Antony he distrusts 'that Cassius' who has 'a lean and hungry look' and 'thinks too much'. He adds that he is not afraid of such men, but only because he does not fear anything.
- A wild storm breaks over Rome with fires in the sky. Casca reads it as a warning. Cassius reads it as a sign that the heavens approve of what he is planning.
- Cassius forges letters, in different handwriting, and throws them into Brutus' window as though from the public.

Act II: The Decision and the Warnings

1. Brutus argues with himself
In his orchard Brutus admits he has no personal reason to hate Caesar. He fears only what Caesar *might* become once crowned, and decides: 'It must be by his death.' He compares ambition to a serpent's egg that must be crushed before it hatches.

2. The conspirators gather
Cassius, Casca, Decius, Cinna, Metellus Cimber and Trebonius meet at Brutus' house. Cassius wants to swear an oath and to kill Antony too. Brutus refuses both: honest men need no oath, and killing Antony would turn a sacrifice into butchery. Brutus also rejects Cicero as a recruit.

3. Portia demands the truth
Portia stabs her own thigh to prove she can keep a secret, and begs her husband to trust her. Brutus is moved and promises to tell her everything later.

4. Calpurnia's dream
Calpurnia dreams that Caesar's statue spouted blood and that Romans bathed in it. She begs him to stay home. He first agrees, saying 'Cowards die many times before their deaths', then yields.

5. Decius turns Caesar around
Decius reinterprets the dream as a sign that Rome will draw life from Caesar, mentions that the senate plans to offer him a crown, and hints that they will laugh at him if he stays at home. Caesar's pride does the rest, and he leaves for the Capitol.

KEY POINT

Who is who? Conspirators: Brutus, Cassius, Casca, Cinna, Decius Brutus, Metellus Cimber, Trebonius. Caesar's side: Caesar, Antony, Calpurnia. Wives: Calpurnia (Caesar), Portia (Brutus). Later arrivals: Octavius and Lepidus.

SIDEKICK TIP

Examiners love one-line setup questions. Remember this chain: **Cassius tempts Brutus, omens warn Caesar, Decius persuades Caesar, Caesar walks into the Senate.**

Questions on Acts I and II

Why does Brutus agree to join the conspiracy even though he loves Caesar?
Brutus has no complaint about what Caesar has done so far. He joins because he is afraid of what power will do to a man, and because he believes the republic must be protected. Cassius' flattering letters and talk of his noble ancestors also convince him that the people expect this from him.

How does Decius change Caesar's mind about staying at home?
He gives the dream a cheerful meaning, tells Caesar that the Senate may offer him a crown, and suggests that Rome will laugh if Caesar stays away because of his wife's dream. Flattery and a touch of mockery work on Caesar's vanity.

HOT QUESTION

HOT: Brutus tells the conspirators 'let us be sacrificers, but not butchers'. What does the difference mean for how he sees the murder?
Think about: a sacrifice is solemn and for a cause; butchery is anger and blood.

02

CHAPTER · JULIUS CAESAR

Act III, Scene 1: The Assassination

The turning point of the whole play. Caesar is killed, Antony makes a clever bargain, and a quiet prophecy of war closes the scene.



IN THIS CHAPTER

- The Capitol
- Metellus' petition
- Et tu, Brute
- Antony's deal
- Dogs of war

Setting and Who Is On Stage

The Capitol, outside the Senate house, on the ides of March. Present: Caesar, Brutus, Cassius, Casca, Decius, Metellus Cimber, Trebonius, Cinna, Publius, Popilius Lena, Artemidorus, the Soothsayer, Antony, a servant of Antony and finally a servant of Octavius.

Scene Summary

Caesar arrives and sees the Soothsayer. 'The ides of March are come,' he says. 'Ay, Caesar, but not gone,' replies the man. Artemidorus presses a paper warning of the plot into Caesar's hand, but Caesar waves him aside: 'What touches us ourself shall be last served.' Popilius Lena whispers to Cassius, 'I wish your enterprise today may thrive.' The conspirators panic, and Cassius threatens to kill himself if they are discovered. Brutus calms him: Lena is smiling and Caesar is not alarmed.

Trebonius leads Antony away so that he cannot help Caesar. Metellus Cimber kneels and asks Caesar to pardon his banished brother. Brutus, Cassius, Cinna and Decius join the plea. Caesar refuses them all, insisting he never changes his mind and calling himself 'constant as the northern star'. Casca shouts 'Speak, hands, for me!' and stabs first. The others follow. When Caesar sees Brutus with a dagger he gives up: 'Et tu, Brute? Then fall, Caesar.'

Chaos follows. Cinna cries 'Liberty! Freedom! Tyranny is dead!' Brutus calms the senators and urges the conspirators to bathe their hands in Caesar's blood and walk out together so that everyone sees what has been done for Rome. Cassius looks ahead and imagines the scene being acted again for centuries.

Antony's servant arrives with a message: Antony will accept Brutus' cause if he is assured of his safety. Brutus agrees. Antony enters, looks at Caesar's body and offers to be killed if the conspirators wish. Brutus promises him respect and a share in the new government. Antony shakes hands with each man, then asks permission to speak at Caesar's funeral. Cassius objects, but Brutus agrees, setting the condition that he speaks first and Antony does not blame them. Left alone with the body, Antony reveals his real feelings and vows revenge. A servant of Octavius brings news, and Antony decides to wait before going to the market-place.

Key Speeches Explained

Caesar refuses Metellus: 'I am constant as the northern star'

Caesar says flatterers might be moved by kneeling, but he is not. He argues that humans are made of flesh and blood, but only some of them have the firmness to stay unmoved, and he is such a man. The speech shows both his strength of will and his arrogance. He compares himself to the Pole Star, which has no equal in the sky. Within seconds he is dead, so the speech is deeply ironic.

Brutus and Cassius after the murder

Brutus tells the senators not to run away: 'ambition's debt is paid'. He wants the killing to look like a lawful act and not a riot, so he asks the men to wash their hands in Caesar's blood up to the elbows and shout 'Peace, freedom and liberty!'. Cassius adds that future ages will act out this scene, and Brutus says Caesar will 'bleed in sport' on stage. The lines are Shakespeare's wink at his own audience: this very play is that re-enactment.

Antony's deal with the conspirators

Antony arrives with great skill. He does not argue; he kneels to the dead hero, says there is no better moment to die than now, and offers himself to their swords. Brutus is flattered and reassured, and Antony gets everything he wants: a hand-shake, safety, and the right to speak. Cassius senses danger but Brutus overrules him.

Antony's soliloquy over the body

Alone, Antony calls the conspirators 'butchers' and Caesar 'the ruins of the noblest man'. He predicts that a curse will fall on Italy, with 'blood and destruction' so common that mothers will merely smile at their babies cut down by war. He sees Caesar's spirit coming 'hot from hell' with Ate, goddess of revenge, and crying 'Havoc!' to unleash 'the dogs of war'. The lines make it clear that the funeral speech is not going to be friendly.

Quotes to Remember

QUOTE	SPEAKER	WHAT IT TELLS US
'Et tu, Brute? Then fall, Caesar.'	Caesar	His last words. He is more hurt by Brutus' betrayal than by the wounds.
'Speak, hands, for me!'	Casca	He strikes first; the conspirators stop talking and act.
'I am constant as the northern star'	Caesar	Boasts of his firmness. It is his fatal pride.
'Liberty! Freedom! Tyranny is dead!'	Cinna	The conspirators claim to have acted for freedom.
'Let's be sacrificers, but not butchers'	Brutus (II.1)	He wants the murder to look noble. Compare with Antony's word 'butchers'.
'O mighty Caesar! Dost thou lie so low?'	Antony	His first words over the corpse. Grief and flattery combined.
'Cry "Havoc!" and let slip the dogs of war'	Antony	Foreshadows civil war across Rome and Italy.
'Though now we must appear bloody and cruel'	Brutus	He claims the deed looks cruel but hearts are full of pity.

Glossary

WORD OR PHRASE	MEANING
Ides of March	15 March, the day the soothsayer had warned about
Suitor / suit	A person making a request / the request itself
Puissant	Powerful
Repeal	To cancel a punishment such as banishment
Bay'd, brave hart	Cornered like a stag (hart) at the hunt; Antony pictures Caesar as the noble stag
Sacrificers, not butchers	Priests of a rite versus cruel killers
Cur	A dog; used as an insult
Cumber	To burden or choke; 'cumber all the parts of Italy' means weigh down the land with war
Ate	Greek goddess of vengeance and ruin
Havoc	Traditional cry giving soldiers the signal to loot and kill without mercy

Context Questions with Model Answers

Extract 1



KEY POINT

'Cry "Havoc!" and let slip the dogs of war; That this foul deed shall smell above the earth With carrion men, groaning for burial.'

(a) Who speaks the lines and to whom?
Antony says them alone on the stage, speaking to Caesar's corpse (the audience overhears them).

(b) What is meant by 'dogs of war'?
The phrase pictures war as a pack of hounds set loose. It means terrible violence: the destruction, killing and suffering of civil war.

(c) Why does Antony say the deed will 'smell above the earth'?
He predicts that so many people will die in the war that their unburied bodies will stink to the heavens. The smell also hints at the moral stench of the murder itself.

(d) What does the speech tell us about Antony?
It shows that his friendliness to the conspirators was a pretence. He is loyal to Caesar, determined on revenge, and is shrewd enough to hide it.

Extract 2

KEY POINT

'I know not, gentlemen, what you intend, Who else must be let blood, who else is rank.'

(a) Who is speaking and who are the 'gentlemen'?
Antony is speaking to the conspirators, including Brutus and Cassius, just after Caesar has fallen.

(b) What does 'let blood' and 'rank' mean here?
Bloodletting meant draining blood as a cure. 'Rank' means diseased or too full of blood. Antony is asking, with irony, which other Roman is next.

(c) How does Brutus answer him?
He assures Antony that he is safe, that the conspirators have no quarrel with him, and that 'our hearts' are 'pitiful' and have acted out of love for Rome.

(d) What impression do you form of Antony here?
He is quick-witted. He appears to place himself at their mercy, which wins Brutus' trust and lets him ask for the right to speak.

HOT Questions

HOT QUESTION

Was Brutus wise to let Antony live and speak? Give two points on each side.
Think about: Brutus' sense of honour, Cassius' warnings, Antony's flattery, what happens in III.2.

HOT QUESTION

How does Caesar's refusal of Metellus' petition prepare the audience for his death?
Think about: Pride, 'northern star', dramatic irony, his failure to hear warnings.

HOT QUESTION

Does Shakespeare want us to sympathise with the conspirators in this scene?
Think about: Brutus' calm leadership versus the image of bloody hands; Antony's description of them as butchers.

Quick Recap

- Caesar ignores Artemidorus' warning, saying that his own concerns come last. Pride makes him careless.
- Metellus' petition is the signal. Casca strikes first; Brutus stabs last; Caesar says 'Et tu, Brute?'.
- Brutus wants the killing to look like a purification, and he washes his hands in blood.
- Antony wins the conspirators' trust, wins permission to speak, then swears to avenge Caesar. The 'dogs of war' speech predicts civil war.

03

CHAPTER · JULIUS CAESAR

Act III, Scene 2: The Funeral Speeches

Two speeches in one scene. Brutus uses logic and loses the crowd. Antony uses emotion and wins it. It is the most tested scene in the play.



IN THIS CHAPTER

- Brutus in prose
- Antony in verse
- Caesar's will
- The mantle
- Mob turns

Setting and Who Is On Stage

The Forum (market-place) in Rome, a short time after the murder. A great crowd of citizens (plebeians) has gathered. Brutus and Cassius arrive and divide the crowd. Brutus speaks from the pulpit; Antony follows with Caesar's body.

Scene Summary

The citizens demand an explanation. Cassius leaves with part of the crowd and Brutus addresses the rest. In calm prose he says that he loved Caesar, but loved Rome more, and that Caesar was ambitious, so he had to die. Not a single citizen argues. They cry out that Brutus should be crowned, and even say they want to put a statue of him up. Brutus stops them and begs them to listen to Antony, who arrives with the body, and leaves.

Antony begins carefully: he has come to bury Caesar, not praise him. Over and over he repeats that Brutus is 'an honourable man'. At the same time he lists facts that cut against the charge of ambition: Caesar brought home captives whose ransoms filled the treasury; he wept for the poor; he refused the crown three times. The crowd starts to murmur that Caesar has been wronged.

Antony then pauses, pretends to weep, and teases them with Caesar's will, which he has in his hand, without reading it. The crowd begs. He first brings them round the body, shows them the mantle Caesar wore on the day he conquered the Nervii, and points out each tear in it: Cassius' dagger, Casca's thrust, and then Brutus' stab, 'the most unkindest cut of all'. The crowd is in tears.

Only then does he read the will: every Roman gets seventy-five drachmas and Caesar's private gardens become a public park. The mob riots, shouting for revenge, and sets off to burn the houses of the conspirators. Antony speaks the famous words 'Mischief, thou art afoot'. A servant tells him that Octavius has arrived in Rome and that Brutus and Cassius have fled.

Key Speeches Explained

Brutus' speech: logic and honour

He opens with 'Romans, countrymen, and lovers', and speaks in prose to sound plain and honest. He shapes it as a balanced argument: 'Not that I loved Caesar less, but that I loved Rome more.' He asks, 'Who is here so base that would be a bondman?', daring anyone to disagree, then claims he will give his own life if Rome needs it. The speech is brief, balanced and noble, but it asks the crowd to trust his word and gives no proof of ambition. It also ends too early, because he leaves and Antony gets the last word.

Antony's speech: five tricks

1. Modest opening: he says he is no orator and will 'speak right on', appearing sincere. **2. Repetition:** 'Brutus is an honourable man' is repeated until it becomes mocking. **3. Evidence:** the ransoms, the tears, the three refusals of the crown. **4. Suspense:** the will is held back to build desire. **5. Visual proof:** the body and the cloak show the wounds, and he lets the 'poor dumb mouths' of the wounds speak. His speech uses pauses, direct address and verse, and he makes the crowd do the thinking, so they believe they reached the conclusion themselves.

The mantle passage

Antony says he remembers the first day Caesar put it on, 'a summer's evening', after the victory over the Nervii. He then points to each hole in turn and names the culprit. By the time he reaches Brutus, Caesar's 'angel', he says that ingratitude overcame the hero more than the traitors' arms did, and Caesar covered his face with the mantle. The cloak turns Caesar from a public figure to a man the crowd can pity.

Quotes to Remember

QUOTE	SPEAKER	WHAT IT TELLS US
'Not that I loved Caesar less, but that I loved Rome more'	Brutus	His whole justification in a single balanced line.
'As he was ambitious, I slew him'	Brutus	His charge against Caesar, which he never proves.
'Friends, Romans, countrymen, lend me your ears'	Antony	A friendly opening that wins attention.
'The evil that men do lives after them'	Antony	Suggests Caesar will be remembered only for faults unless defended.
'Brutus is an honourable man'	Antony	Repeated until it turns to sarcasm.
'Ambition should be made of sterner stuff'	Antony	Caesar wept for the poor; a harsh man would not.
'This was the most unkindest cut of all'	Antony	Brutus' stab hurt Caesar most.
'Mischief, thou art afoot'	Antony	He has set the mob moving and does not mind what follows.

Glossary

WORD OR PHRASE	MEANING
Plebeians	Ordinary citizens of Rome
Lovers	In Brutus' usage, dear friends
Bondman	A slave
Interred	Buried
Coffers	Treasury or money boxes
Brutish beasts	Animals who lack reason; Antony says judgement has fled to them
Mutiny	Open revolt
Nervii	A fierce tribe in Gaul that Caesar defeated in 57 BC
Dint of pity	The impression or blow of pity
Drachma	A silver Greek coin; 75 drachmas were a considerable sum
Mischief	Evil, trouble or harm

Context Questions with Model Answers

Extract 1



KEY POINT

'The noble Brutus Hath told you Caesar was ambitious: If it were so, it was a grievous fault, And grievously hath Caesar answer'd it.'

(a) Who says this and where?
Antony, in the Forum, during the funeral oration, with Caesar's body on the stage.

(b) What does 'it was a grievous fault' mean?
If the charge of ambition were true, it would be a serious fault and Caesar has paid heavily for it, through his death.

(c) Does Antony agree with Brutus?
No. He pretends to accept the charge ('if it were so') but is gently doubting it, and a few lines later he gives proof against it.

(d) What method is Antony using?
He is using irony. He says one thing and means another, and relies on the audience reading between the lines.

Extract 2

KEY POINT

'Who is here so base that would be a bondman? If any, speak; for him have I offended.'

(a) Who is the speaker, and who is the audience?
Brutus speaks to the Roman citizens in the Forum just after Caesar's death.

(b) What does 'bondman' mean?
A slave.

(c) Why does Brutus ask this?
He wants the citizens to see that to disagree with him is to say they would accept slavery under a king.

(d) How do the people respond, and what does that show?
They shout 'None, Brutus, none'. It shows that the crowd is swayed by simple, strong phrases, and that Brutus convinced them with emotion and not with facts.

HOT Questions

HOT QUESTION

Both speeches use persuasion. Why does Antony succeed where Brutus fails?
Think about: Prose versus verse, logic versus emotion, evidence, the body and the will.

HOT QUESTION

Does Antony break his promise to Brutus not to blame the conspirators?
Think about: He says he will not harm them, but his repeated 'honourable man' does exactly that.

HOT QUESTION

Is the mob wiser than its leaders, or merely fickle?
Think about: Their rapid change from cheering Brutus to hunting him; 'O judgment! thou art fled to brutish beasts'.

Quick Recap

- Brutus speaks in prose, uses balanced logic and expects honour to be enough.
- Antony wins the crowd with irony, evidence, suspense, the wounded cloak and Caesar's will.
- The will leaves 75 drachmas to every citizen and the public use of Caesar's gardens.
- The mob riots. 'Mischief, thou art afoot' shows Antony's satisfaction. Brutus and Cassius flee.

04

CHAPTER · JULIUS CAESAR

Act III, Scene 3: Cinna the Poet

A very short scene with a big message: once a crowd is set free, it cannot tell friend from enemy. The victim is a poet who had never plotted anything.



IN THIS CHAPTER

- A street in Rome
- Mistaken identity
- Mob violence
- Short but tested

Setting and Who Is On Stage

A street in Rome, right after the riot. Cinna the poet is on his way to Caesar's funeral. A group of angry plebeians stop him.

Scene Summary

Cinna the poet has had a bad dream in which he feasted with Caesar, and something unlucky seems to push him out of doors even though he does not want to go. A group of plebeians surround him and demand to know his name, destination and home. They tease him with questions about whether he is married or single, and threaten him when he says he is on his way to Caesar's funeral.

When he gives his name as Cinna, the mob shouts that he is a conspirator, as Cinna the conspirator was part of Brutus' band. He explains twice that he is Cinna the poet. The mob refuses to listen: 'Tear him for his bad verses.' They drag him off and then go out to burn the houses of Brutus, Cassius and other conspirators.

Key Speeches Explained

The mob's logic

A name is all that matters to the crowd. One citizen cries 'Tear him to pieces; he's a conspirator', another says he is 'Cinna the poet' and the mob answers 'Tear him for his bad verses'. Their reasoning is absurd: if he is a conspirator, he dies; if not, he still dies. Shakespeare shows how cruelty needs no reason once people are in a mob.

Why Shakespeare put the scene here

It comes straight after Antony's speech. Antony said 'Mischief, thou art afoot'; this scene shows the mischief. The scene is also the first sign of the civil strife Antony predicted in III.1. It makes us ask whether Antony, who let the mob loose, is any better than the conspirators.

Quotes to Remember

QUOTE	SPEAKER	WHAT IT TELLS US
'I am Cinna the poet'	Cinna the poet	He is begging for his life; he is the wrong Cinna.
'Tear him to pieces; he's a conspirator'	Third Plebeian	A killing based only on a name.
'Tear him for his bad verses'	Fourth Plebeian	Violence has become senseless.
'Something unlucky hurts me'	Cinna the poet	He senses danger; foreshadowing.

Glossary

WORD OR PHRASE	MEANING
Cinna	Cinna the poet, a harmless friend of Caesar, who shares a name with Cinna the conspirator
Conspirator	A person who plots secretly with others
Bachelor	An unmarried man
Turn him going	Send him off (to his death)
Brands	Burning torches or pieces of wood

Context Questions with Model Answers

Extract 1



KEY POINT

'Tear him for his bad verses, tear him for his bad verses.'

(a) Who says this, and about whom?
A plebeian says this about Cinna the poet.

(b) What has just happened?
Cinna has told the mob that he is the poet, not the conspirator.

(c) What does the line show about the crowd?
That the mob is not interested in truth. It wants blood, and any excuse will do.

(d) What is the effect on the audience?
Cruel humour turns to horror; the audience understands that Antony's mischief has produced violence against innocent people.

HOT Questions



HOT QUESTION

Is this scene comic or tragic? Argue for one.
Think about: Banter about marriage and verses against the real killing.



HOT QUESTION

How does Shakespeare use the scene to criticise the mob?
Think about: Mistaken identity, no reasoning, repeated 'tear him'.

Quick Recap

- Cinna the poet is mistaken for Cinna the conspirator and killed by the mob.
- The scene shows the consequences of Antony's speech.
- It is a short but powerful commentary on mob violence and on the cost of civil unrest.

05

CHAPTER · JULIUS CAESAR

Act IV, Scene 1: The Triumvirate

The avengers organise. Antony, Octavius and Lepidus share power, draw up a death list and, in a quiet aside, Antony shows a ruthless side.



IN THIS CHAPTER

- Rome, a house
- Proscription list
- Lepidus belittled
- Preparing for war

Setting and Who Is On Stage

A house in Rome. Antony, Octavius and Lepidus sit at a table with a list of names. Time has passed since the funeral; the three men now rule Rome together as the Second Triumvirate.

Scene Summary

The three men go through a list of people to be put to death. Antony marks names without hesitation. Octavius says Lepidus' own brother must die, and Lepidus consents, but on one condition: that Publius, Antony's sister's son, also dies. Antony agrees at once and marks the name: 'He shall not live; look, with a spot I damn him.' Family ties count for nothing on this list.

Antony sends Lepidus to Caesar's house to fetch the will so they can decide how to cut some of the legacies. Once Lepidus has gone, Antony tells Octavius that Lepidus is 'a slight unmeritable man, meet to be sent on errands' and not fit to share power. Octavius points out that Lepidus is a tried soldier. Antony replies that his horse is one too, and compares Lepidus to a horse that must be trained. Antony then says they will use him only as long as it suits them.

Antony finishes by saying their enemies Brutus and Cassius are gathering armies, and that they must prepare. Octavius agrees, warning that they are 'at the stake' and surrounded, and that many who smile at them hide 'millions of mischiefs'.

Key Speeches Explained

Antony the politician

The Antony of the funeral speech seemed to act out of love. Here we see he is also a cold political operator. He is willing to sacrifice family members, uses Lepidus for convenience, and treats names on a list as marks. This does not cancel his grief for Caesar, but it warns the audience that revenge and power are mixed in his mind.

The horse speech

Antony says Lepidus is like a horse that eats and does what it is told: 'he must be taught and train'd and bid go forth'. A horse is useful, but is not asked for opinions. Antony intends to use Lepidus' name and then discard him. It also shows that the new triumvirate is not a team of equals, which sets up future conflict between Antony and Octavius.

Octavius' warning

Octavius is young but sharp. He is the one who says they are 'bay'd about with many enemies', and that open dangers must be answered openly. He is the quieter figure who will end up winning the empire.

Quotes to Remember

QUOTE	SPEAKER	WHAT IT TELLS US
'Prick him down, Antony.'	Octavius	He is ready to mark names; he is hard in his own way.
'He shall not live; look, with a spot I damn him.'	Antony	A dot of ink is all it takes to condemn Publius.
'A slight unmeritable man, meet to be sent on errands'	Antony	His contempt for Lepidus.
'We are at the stake, And bay'd about with many enemies'	Octavius	They are surrounded like a bear tied to a post.
'Some that smile have in their hearts... millions of mischiefs'	Octavius	Warns against false friends.

Glossary

WORD OR PHRASE	MEANING
Triumvirate	A government of three men
Proscription (pricked down)	A list of people condemned to death; names were marked with a pen-prick
Unmeritable	Without merit or worth
Meet	Suitable, fit
Legacies	Money or property left to people in a will
Provender	Animal feed such as hay or oats
Bay'd about	Surrounded like an animal cornered by dogs
Covert matters	Hidden or secret plans

Context Questions with Model Answers

Extract 1



KEY POINT

'This is a slight unmeritable man, Meet to be sent on errands: is it fit, The three-fold world divided, he should stand One of the three to share it?'

(a) Who speaks, and about whom?

Antony speaks to Octavius about Lepidus after Lepidus has left the room.

(b) What does 'three-fold world divided' refer to?
The Roman world split between the three men: Antony, Octavius and Lepidus.

(c) What does Octavius say in reply?
He says Lepidus has been proved a valiant soldier and that Antony himself once allowed him to share the honour.

(d) What does the speech reveal about Antony?
That he is calculating and ready to use others, and that he has an eye on power, not only on revenge.

HOT Questions

HOT QUESTION
Do the triumvirs differ from the conspirators in their methods? Give reasons.
Think about: Lists of names, personal revenge, Brutus' 'sacrificers, not butchers'.

HOT QUESTION
Why does Shakespeare place this scene between the funeral and the quarrel scene?
Think about: Contrast of the two camps: calculation versus conscience.

Quick Recap

- The triumvirs are Antony, Octavius and Lepidus.
- They agree on a death list, trading away relatives.
- Antony privately scorns Lepidus as a mere tool.
- They prepare for war against Brutus and Cassius, who are raising armies.

06

CHAPTER · JULIUS CAESAR

Act IV, Scene 2: Trouble at the Camp

A short scene: Brutus and Cassius meet at Sardis and the first cracks in their friendship show. It sets up the great quarrel that follows.



IN THIS CHAPTER

- Camp near Sardis
- A hot friend cooling
- Public quarrel postponed

Setting and Who Is On Stage

Before Brutus' tent in the camp near Sardis (in Asia Minor), with drums sounding. Present: Brutus, Lucilius, Lucius (Brutus' servant), Titinius, Pindarus, and soldiers. Cassius arrives with his army.

Scene Summary

Brutus asks Lucilius how Cassius received him. Lucilius says Cassius was courteous but not as warm as before. Brutus draws the lesson: a friendship that begins to fade turns to formal politeness. He compares insincere friends to hot-tempered horses that make a fine show but give way at the first spur.

Cassius arrives and immediately accuses Brutus of wronging him. Brutus replies that he has not wronged anybody, but also insists that the quarrel must not be fought in front of the soldiers. He tells Cassius to speak 'softly' and invites him into the tent, where they can talk in private. Guards are posted at the door.

Key Speeches Explained

'A hot friend cooling'

Brutus senses that Cassius has changed. His observation about enforced ceremony applies to every relationship: when real warmth fades, people replace it with courtesy. The line is also a hint about the friendship we are about to see tested.

Brutus' calm control

Even when Cassius is accusing him, Brutus stays composed and thinks of the effect on the army. The quarrel in IV.3 shows that he is not always so calm, but here he is the better leader.

Quotes to Remember

QUOTE	SPEAKER	WHAT IT TELLS US
'Thou hast described A hot friend cooling'	Brutus	Spots the early signs of a break in the friendship.
'When love begins to sicken and decay, It useth an enforced ceremony'	Brutus	Coldness hides behind politeness.
'Most noble brother, you have done me wrong'	Cassius	Opens the quarrel.
'Speak your griefs softly'	Brutus	He wants the dispute kept private.

Glossary

WORD OR PHRASE	MEANING
Sardis	An ancient city in Asia Minor (now in Turkey)
Enforced ceremony	Forced politeness
Jades	Weak, worn-out horses
Mettle	Spirit and courage
Griefs	Complaints or grievances
Enlarge your griefs	Explain your complaints in full

Context Questions with Model Answers

Extract 1



KEY POINT

'When love begins to sicken and decay, It useth an enforced ceremony. There are no tricks in plain and simple faith.'

(a) Who says it, and about whom?
Brutus says it to Lucilius, about Cassius' reception.

(b) What does 'enforced ceremony' mean?
Politeness that is strained and unnatural, put on to hide a loss of real feeling.

(c) What is the meaning of the last line?
Genuine friendship needs no show; it is straightforward.

(d) How does this speech prepare for the next scene?
It warns us that the friendship between the two men is under strain, and the open quarrel follows at once.

HOT Questions



HOT QUESTION

Why does Brutus insist that the quarrel be held indoors?
Think about: Public image, discipline of troops, both are generals.

Quick Recap

- Brutus and Cassius meet near Sardis.
- Brutus feels his friend is cooling and says forced courtesy is a bad sign.

- Cassius accuses Brutus of wrongs; Brutus takes him into the tent to talk privately.

07

CHAPTER · JULIUS CAESAR

Act IV, Scene 3: The Quarrel and the Ghost

A great scene with three parts: an explosive quarrel, the news of Portia's death, and the first appearance of Caesar's ghost. Every ICSE paper draws from it.



IN THIS CHAPTER

- Inside the tent
- Itching palm
- Reconciliation
- Portia's death
- Caesar's ghost

Setting and Who Is On Stage

Inside Brutus' tent at Sardis. First the two commanders are alone with a poet outside. Later Lucius, Titinius, Messala, Varro and Claudius join them. At night Brutus is alone, with Lucius asleep. Time: the evening before the march to Philippi.

Scene Summary

Cassius complains that Brutus punished Lucius Pella for taking bribes, even though Cassius had written to ask for mercy. Brutus replies that Cassius has been selling offices for money and that the murder of Caesar was supposed to end such corruption. 'Did not great Julius bleed for justice' sake?' he asks. The two shout at each other. Cassius says that he is an older and more experienced soldier; Brutus says that he fears no threats, 'armed so strong in honesty'. Brutus adds that Cassius refused him gold for his legions.

Cassius breaks down. He offers his dagger and his bare breast to Brutus: 'Strike, as thou didst at Caesar.' Brutus sheathes the weapon and the two are reconciled. Even a poet who bursts in with a plea to 'Love, and be friends' is sent away. Brutus then admits why he is so short-tempered: Portia is dead. She was frantic with fear that Octavius and Antony were gaining strength and, having been left alone, 'swallowed fire'. Cassius is horrified. Brutus calls for wine to bury all unkindness.

Messala and Titinius bring news that Octavius, Antony and Lepidus have put to death a hundred senators (Brutus says seventy), including Cicero. Messala asks Brutus about Portia. Brutus pretends to know nothing; when Messala tells him she is dead, Brutus accepts the news calmly: 'Why, farewell, Portia. We must die, Messala.' Cassius admires his self-control.

The two debate strategy. Cassius wants to wait and let the enemy come to them, but Brutus insists on marching to meet them at Philippi because the people between there and Sardis only help them reluctantly. He reminds Cassius that 'there is a tide in the affairs of men', which, if missed, leads only to misery. Cassius gives in. When the others sleep, Brutus stays up to read. The candle burns low and the ghost of Caesar appears. It calls itself 'thy evil spirit' and promises, 'Thou shalt see me at Philippi.' Brutus wakes his men, but none of them have seen anything.

Key Speeches Explained

The quarrel: why it matters

Brutus accuses Cassius of an 'itching palm', meaning greed. His own principle is that they killed Caesar for justice, so they cannot now use dishonest means. He declares he would rather 'coin my heart, and drop my blood for drachmas' than steal from poor farmers. Cassius answers with injured pride, and wounded love: 'Brutus hath rived my heart'. The quarrel shows two ways of being a leader. Brutus is principled but sometimes self-righteous (yet he himself asked Cassius for the money); Cassius is practical but sentimental.

Cassius' dagger

'There is my dagger, And here my naked breast.' It is a theatrical gesture, offering the same kind of weapon used on Caesar, and with it a reminder that Cassius has always loved Brutus more than Caesar. Brutus' reply, 'Sheathe your dagger', ends the quarrel. The reconciliation is warm, but it also shows Cassius' emotional weakness.

The Portia news

The scene reveals Brutus' real burden, in a quiet and shocking way. He does not scream or weep; he tells Cassius briefly. Later, in front of the others, he pretends to hear it for the first time. Critics debate whether this is a Roman performance of stoicism or Shakespeare's inconsistency, as there are two accounts of her death. Either way, it shows Brutus' public self-control.

The 'tide in the affairs of men'

Brutus says that a moment of opportunity must be seized 'at the flood', or the voyage of life will be 'bound in shallows and in miseries'. He uses it to justify an early march. In hindsight, his choice to leave the high ground and march to Philippi is the strategic error that loses the battle, so the speech is ironic.

The ghost

Caesar's ghost is called Brutus' 'evil spirit'. It does not speak of revenge in detail, only of Philippi, where Brutus will meet it again. Brutus' reaction is not terror but courage, as he says 'Why, I will see thee at Philippi, then.' The ghost marks the turn from Brutus' confidence to doom.

Quotes to Remember

QUOTE	SPEAKER	WHAT IT TELLS US
'You yourself Are much condemn'd to have an itching palm'	Brutus	Accuses Cassius of greed and selling offices.
'Did not great Julius bleed for justice' sake?'	Brutus	Caesar's murder was for principle, so no corruption is allowed.
'I had rather be a dog, and bay the moon, Than such a Roman'	Brutus	Better to be a howling dog than a corrupt Roman.
'Armed so strong in honesty'	Brutus	Threats pass by him like 'the idle wind'.
'A friend should bear his friend's infirmities'	Cassius	He asks for patience; Brutus replies he does not, till faults are 'practised on me'.
'Strike, as thou didst at Caesar'	Cassius	He offers his life in despair.
'Portia is dead'	Brutus	The reason for his sorrow and his temper.
'There is a tide in the affairs of men'	Brutus	Take chances at the right moment.
'Thy evil spirit, Brutus'	Ghost of Caesar	Caesar's ghost names itself and promises Philippi.

Glossary

WORD OR PHRASE	MEANING
Chastisement	Punishment
Itching palm	A greedy hand always wanting money; a love of bribes
Mart your offices	Trade government posts for money
Indirection	Dishonest, roundabout means
Choler / spleen	Anger; the spleen was believed to be the seat of temper
Vaunting	Boasting
Rived	Split or torn apart
Drachmas	Coins; here money
Philosophy (stoic)	Brutus' belief in self-control in the face of suffering
Apparition	A ghost
Philippi	A city in Macedonia where the final battle takes place

Context Questions with Model Answers

Extract 1



KEY POINT

'There is no terror, Cassius, in your threats; For I am arm'd so strong in honesty That they pass by me as the idle wind, Which I respect not.'

(a) Who is speaking to whom, and in what situation?
Brutus says this to Cassius in the tent at Sardis, during their quarrel.

(b) What does Brutus mean by being 'arm'd so strong in honesty'?
That he is protected by his honest conscience, as a soldier is by armour, so threats cannot harm him.

(c) What image is used, and how effective is it?
The threats are compared to 'the idle wind', meaning they are harmless and ignored. The picture makes Brutus' contempt vivid.

(d) What does he go on to accuse Cassius of?
Refusing him money to pay his legions, while himself taking bribes. Brutus says he cannot raise funds by 'vile means'.

Extract 2

KEY POINT

'Hated by one he loves; braved by his brother; Check'd like a bondman; all his faults observ'd, Set in a note-book, learn'd, and conn'd by rote.'

(a) Who speaks and what has provoked it?
Cassius, after Brutus has criticised him harshly.

(b) Explain 'check'd like a bondman'.
Scolded as a slave would be.

(c) What complaint is he making about Brutus?
That Brutus keeps a record of his faults and throws them in his face, which is not how a friend behaves.

(d) How is the quarrel ended?
Cassius offers his dagger, Brutus tells him to sheathe it, admits he was ill-tempered and the two shake hands.

HOT Questions

HOT QUESTION

Who is right in the quarrel: Brutus or Cassius? Justify your answer.
Think about: Brutus' moral claims against his own request for money; Cassius' wounded love.

HOT QUESTION

Why does Shakespeare reveal Portia's death during the quarrel, and not before?
Think about: Explains Brutus' temper, deepens sympathy, shows his stoic mask.

HOT QUESTION

What does the ghost represent: guilt, fate or a real supernatural presence?
Think about: the dim candle, Brutus' tired state, Philippi, 'evil spirit'.

HOT QUESTION

How does the 'tide' speech reveal both Brutus' strength and his flaw?
Think about: Idealism, readiness to act, ignoring Cassius' advice.

Quick Recap

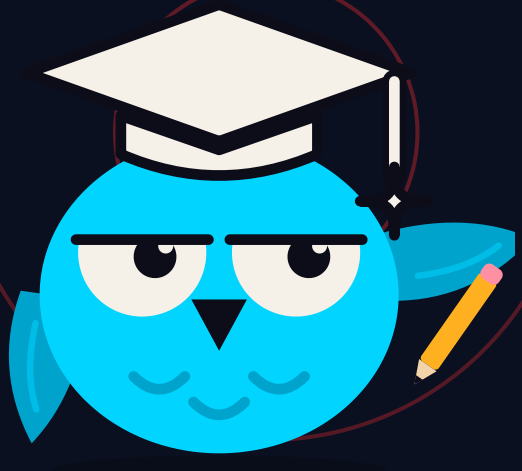
- Brutus blames Cassius for corruption; Cassius blames Brutus for coldness.
- The quarrel ends with Cassius offering his dagger, and they make up.
- Portia has killed herself by swallowing fire; Brutus bears the news with stoic control.
- Brutus overrides Cassius' strategy and decides to march to Philippi.
- Caesar's ghost appears and promises to meet Brutus at Philippi.

08

CHAPTER · JULIUS CAESAR

Act V, Scene 1: The Parley at Philippi

The armies face each other on the plains. Before the fight come insults, a farewell between old friends, and Cassius' sudden fear of omens.



IN THIS CHAPTER

- Plains of Philippi
- War of words
- Cassius' omens
- Farewell

Setting and Who Is On Stage

The plains of Philippi in Macedonia. The armies of Octavius and Antony on one side; the army of Brutus and Cassius on the other. Present: Octavius, Antony, Brutus, Cassius, Lucilius, Titinius, Messala.

Scene Summary

Antony says he expected the enemy to stay in the hills, but they have come down to the plain, and he is glad. A messenger confirms they are close. Antony and Octavius then quarrel over the placing of their troops: Octavius wants the right wing and Antony tells him to keep to the left. Antony says 'Why do you cross me in this exigent?' Octavius replies, 'I do not cross you; but I will do so.'

The enemy leaders arrive and a parley (a war of words) takes place. Antony taunts Brutus and Cassius: they gave good words but bad strokes. He reminds them how they hacked Caesar's sides, bowed like slaves and kissed his feet, and cried 'Hail, Caesar!' as they pierced his heart, while Casca struck from behind like a cur. Cassius replies angrily that if his advice had been taken, Antony would have been killed. Octavius ends it: 'Look, I draw a sword against conspirators.' He will not sheathe it, he says, until Caesar's three and thirty wounds are avenged.

Brutus tells Octavius he cannot be killed by traitors' hands unless he brings them. Octavius says he was not born to die on Brutus' sword. Cassius scoffs at him as a 'peevish schoolboy'. The enemy leaves.

Cassius confesses to Messala that he was once an Epicurean, but is now shaken because two eagles that perched on his standards have flown away and been replaced by crows and kites. It is also his birthday. Cassius then asks Brutus what he will do if they lose. Brutus says he disapproved of Cato's suicide, but now thinks it vile to take one's life from fear of what may happen. Yet he refuses to be led in chains to Rome. The two say farewell, hoping to smile if they meet again.

Key Speeches Explained

The verbal fight

Antony is the master of insults, as he was of oratory. He uses the same strategy as at the funeral: he brings Caesar's wounds into the argument. Cassius, who believes Antony should have been killed, uses the word 'flatterers' in return. Octavius' short words show that he is more serious than he seems, and from now on he, not Antony, sets the pace.

Cassius' change of mind

Cassius has been a sceptic and dismissed omens, but on the eve of battle his confidence has gone. He tells Messala that he used to hold to the philosophy of Epicurus, but that he now changes his mind and partly believes in signs that foretell the future. His fear contrasts with the defiance he showed earlier and prepares for his mistaken suicide in V.3.

The farewell

The two friends discuss what they would do if defeated. Brutus rejects both suicide and surrender, but they leave the question unresolved. Their parting, 'For ever, and for ever, farewell, Cassius!', is moving because they will not meet again alive. The words 'we shall smile' show Brutus' brave cheer.

Quotes to Remember

QUOTE	SPEAKER	WHAT IT TELLS US
'In your bad strokes, Brutus, you give good words'	Antony	He mocks the conspirators' hypocrisy.
'I was not born to die on Brutus' sword'	Octavius	Pride in his young self; he treats Brutus as a traitor.
'Till Caesar's three and thirty wounds Be well aveng'd'	Octavius	His oath not to sheathe the sword.
'A peevish schoolboy'	Cassius	He sneers at Octavius' youth.
'This is my birth-day; as this very day Was Cassius born'	Cassius	Cassius feels the day is fateful.
'For ever, and for ever, farewell, Cassius!'	Brutus	A final goodbye between friends.

Glossary

WORD OR PHRASE	MEANING
Parley	A meeting between enemies to talk before fighting
Exigent	Moment of crisis
Fawn	To flatter like a dog
Peevish	Childish and bad-tempered
Epicurus / Epicurean	A Greek philosopher who denied that gods interfere in life; his followers disbelieved omens
Presage	To foretell, to give a sign of the future
Carrion	Dead, rotting flesh
Cato	Brutus' father-in-law, a Roman who killed himself rather than be captured

Context Questions with Model Answers

Extract 1



KEY POINT

'I draw a sword against conspirators; When think you that the sword goes up again? Never, till Caesar's three and thirty wounds Be well aveng'd; or till another Caesar Have added slaughter to the sword of traitors.'

(a) Who is the speaker and who is he addressing?
Octavius, addressing Brutus, Cassius and their officers at the parley at Philippi.

(b) What does he promise?
That he will not put his sword away until Caesar's murderers are punished, or until he himself is killed, 'another Caesar' falling to traitors.

(c) What does 'three and thirty wounds' refer to?
The number of stab wounds Caesar received (a historical detail).

(d) What does this speech show about Octavius' character?
He is young but determined and ready to lead, and he uses the memory of Caesar to rally his men.

Extract 2



KEY POINT
'This is my birth-day; as this very day Was Cassius born. Give me thy hand, Messala.'

(a) Who says it, and to whom?
Cassius, to Messala before the battle.

(b) What is the significance of the day?
It is Cassius' birthday, and he feels uneasily that he will die on the day he was born.

(c) What omens does Cassius mention?
Two eagles perched on his standards at Sardis and fed from the soldiers' hands; today ravens, crows and kites circle over his troops as if waiting for a dying army.

(d) How has Cassius changed from earlier in the play?
He once held that omens meant nothing, but now he partly believes in them. This shows his loss of confidence.

HOT Questions



HOT QUESTION
Why does Shakespeare give Cassius, the sceptic, a belief in omens at this point?
Think about: Fear before battle, loss of control, pattern of fate.



HOT QUESTION
Compare the farewell of Brutus and Cassius with their quarrel in IV.3.
Think about: Love versus anger, equal footing, mutual respect.

Quick Recap

- The two armies meet on the plains of Philippi and trade insults.
- Octavius draws his sword and vows to avenge Caesar's 33 wounds.
- Cassius, though once a sceptic, fears the omens and recalls it is his birthday.
- Brutus says he will not be led captive to Rome; the friends part, 'for ever'.

09

CHAPTER · JULIUS CAESAR

Act V, Scene 2: The Order to Attack

A very short battle scene. Brutus sees a chance and sends the signal, a decision that costs him dearly.



IN THIS CHAPTER

- The battlefield
- Messala's errand
- Brutus acts too early

Setting and Who Is On Stage

The field of battle at Philippi. Loud alarums (trumpet calls and fighting noises) are heard. Brutus and Messala are the only speakers.

Scene Summary

Brutus gives Messala written orders for the legions on the other side of the field, which are led by Cassius. He says they should all attack at once, because he can see a 'cold demeanour' in Octavius' wing, and a sudden push would overthrow it. He repeats the order: 'Ride, ride, Messala: let them all come down.'

Key Speeches Explained

Why the scene matters

The scene is only a few lines, but it moves the plot. Brutus' army attacks Octavius' wing and wins, but in doing so his men break ranks to plunder. Cassius' wing, left without support, is overrun by Antony. The mistake therefore lies in Brutus' hurry and in his failure to plan with Cassius, who had advised caution at Sardis.

Quotes to Remember

QUOTE	SPEAKER	WHAT IT TELLS US
'Ride, ride, Messala, ride, and give these bills'	Brutus	Orders carried by a messenger.
'Let them set on at once'	Brutus	A general attack, not co-ordinated.
'Cold demeanour in Octavius' wing'	Brutus	He sees weakness in Octavius' troops.

Glossary

WORD OR PHRASE	MEANING
Alarum	A call to arms; battle noise
Bills	Written orders
Demeanour	Behaviour or bearing
Set on	Attack

Context Questions with Model Answers

Extract 1

KEY POINT

'Ride, ride, Messala, ride, and give these bills Unto the legions on the other side.'

(a) Who speaks and what are the 'bills'?
Brutus speaks to Messala; the bills are written battle orders.

(b) To whom are the orders to be given?
To the legions commanded by Cassius.

(c) What does Brutus want them to do?
Attack at once, because he has noticed a 'cold demeanour' in Octavius' troops.

(d) What are the consequences of this order?
The attack is not co-ordinated. Brutus' men win ground but start looting, and Cassius is left to face Antony alone.

HOT Questions

HOT QUESTION

Does Brutus lose the battle through bad judgement or bad luck?
Think about: Early order, Cassius' advice at Sardis, the 'tide' speech.

Quick Recap

- Brutus sends orders for an immediate full attack.
- He believes Octavius' wing is weak.
- The haste leads to confusion in V.3.

10

CHAPTER · JULIUS CAESAR

Act V, Scene 3: The Deaths of Cassius and Titinius

A tragedy of misunderstanding. Cassius dies because he trusts his eyes and his fear instead of his friends. It is the emotional peak of the battle.



IN THIS CHAPTER

- Another part of the field
- Titinius captured?
- Cassius' death
- Titinius' suicide
- Last of the Romans

Setting and Who Is On Stage

Another part of the field of Philippi. Present: Cassius, Titinius, Pindarus (Cassius' servant), Messala, Brutus, young Cato, Lucilius, Flavius, soldiers. Cassius' bondman Pindarus watches from a hill.

Scene Summary

Cassius sees his own men fleeing. He killed a cowardly standard-bearer and took the flag himself. Titinius brings word that Brutus' soldiers, having defeated Octavius, left the fight to loot, so Antony has surrounded Cassius' camp. Antony's men are close, and Cassius withdraws up a hill.

Cassius sends Titinius to find out whether a troop of horsemen in the distance are friends or enemies and tells Pindarus to climb the hill and watch. Pindarus, seeing the horsemen surround Titinius and hearing a shout, reports wrongly that Titinius is captured. In truth the horsemen are Brutus' men and the shout is of joy.

Cassius, believing that his best friend is lost, decides to die on his birthday. He reminds Pindarus, a Parthian captive he spared on condition of obedience, of his promise. 'Search this bosom' with the same sword that killed Caesar. Pindarus obeys. Cassius' last words are 'Caesar, thou art reveng'd, Even with the sword that kill'd thee.' Pindarus, now free, flees far away, grieved that he has made such a mistake.

Messala and Titinius return in triumph, only to find the body. Titinius, grief-stricken, puts a garland on his dead friend's brow, then kills himself with Cassius' sword, calling it 'a Roman's part'. Brutus arrives and sees both bodies. He says 'O Julius Caesar, thou art mighty yet!' and praises Cassius as 'the last of all the Romans'. Brutus orders the body sent to Thasos for burial so that mourning does not lower the army's spirits, and rallies the troops for a second battle.

Key Speeches Explained

Cassius' mistaken despair

Cassius believes what he sees from a distance and what Pindarus says; he does not wait for proof. The tragedy is built on misreading: the shout is joy, not capture. Messala names the cause: 'O hateful error, melancholy's child', the error 'soon conceived' that 'kill'st the mother that engender'd thee'. The mother is Cassius, since the mistaken conclusion kills the man who made it.

The sword that killed Caesar

Cassius uses the same sword on himself, so Caesar is 'revenged'. This echoes Caesar's ghost and the theme of fate: the conspirators strike down Caesar, and his death comes back to them. Brutus says it clearly: 'Thy spirit walks abroad, and turns our swords In our proper entrails.'

Titinius' lament and sacrifice

'The sun of Rome is set!' Titinius says. As the sun sets in red light, Cassius' day ends in red blood. His suicide shows the Roman idea of honour and friendship: he will not live after Cassius. Brutus' tribute, 'Are yet two Romans living such as these?', acknowledges two noble men lost.

Brutus' tribute to Cassius

'The last of all the Romans, fare thee well!' Brutus says that Rome will never again produce a man like him. He promises to find time to mourn, but not in the camp, where grief might discourage the soldiers. It shows Brutus the leader and the friend at once.

Quotes to Remember

QUOTE	SPEAKER	WHAT IT TELLS US
'Caesar, thou art reveng'd, Even with the sword that kill'd thee'	Cassius	His dying words; he sees himself punished by Caesar.
'O hateful error, melancholy's child'	Messala	Blames the false report and Cassius' gloomy mood.
'The sun of Rome is set!'	Titinius	Cassius' death ends Rome's brightness and hope.
'This is a Roman's part: Come, Cassius' sword, and find Titinius' heart'	Titinius	He chooses death before dishonour.
'O Julius Caesar, thou art mighty yet!'	Brutus	Caesar's spirit seems to be winning.
'The last of all the Romans, fare thee well!'	Brutus	Tribute to Cassius' greatness.
'I shall find time, Cassius, I shall find time'	Brutus	Promise to mourn later; there is a battle to fight.

Glossary

WORD OR PHRASE	MEANING
Standard / ensign	The flag carried into battle
Pindarus	Cassius' bondman, once a prisoner in Parthia
Parthia	An ancient kingdom in present-day Iran
Bondman	A slave or servant
Misconstrued	Misunderstood
Garland	A wreath of leaves or flowers
Thasos	An island off the coast near Philippi where Cassius' body is sent
Proper entrails	Our own insides; our own bodies
Compass	Course or limit; 'my life is run his compass' means my life has run its course

Context Questions with Model Answers

Extract 1

KEY POINT
'Time is come round, And where I did begin, there shall I end; My life is run his compass.'

(a) Who says this and what is the occasion?
Cassius, on the hill at Philippi, after Pindarus says Titinius has been captured.

(b) What does he mean by 'time is come round'?
The day is Cassius' birthday, so his life has come full circle.

(c) What does he ask Pindarus to do and why?
To kill him with the sword that killed Caesar, as Pindarus once promised obedience in exchange for his life.

(d) What is ironic about Cassius' death?
He dies because of a misreading: Titinius was not captured. His despair was needless.

Extract 2

KEY POINT
'Are yet two Romans living such as these? The last of all the Romans, fare thee well! It is impossible that ever Rome Should breed thy fellow.'

(a) Who speaks, and over whose body?
Brutus, over the bodies of Cassius and Titinius.

(b) What does 'the last of all the Romans' suggest?
That Cassius was the final example of true Roman nobility and courage.

(c) What does Brutus decide about the funeral and why?
That the body should go to Thasos for burial, not stay in the camp, because grief would depress the army.

(d) What does the tribute reveal about Brutus?
His generosity, his love of friends, and his sense of duty as a general.

HOT Questions

HOT QUESTION
Is Cassius a victim of his own character or of bad luck?
Think about: Pindarus' mistake, Cassius' lack of patience, sword symbolism.

HOT QUESTION
Why is Titinius' suicide important to the play's picture of friendship?
Think about: Loyalty, the 'Roman's part', the garland.

HOT QUESTION

In what sense is Caesar 'mighty yet'?

Think about: Ghost, sword, civil strife, revenge theme.

Quick Recap

- Brutus' men loot; Antony surrounds Cassius.
- Pindarus misreports the fate of Titinius; Cassius has himself killed with the sword that killed Caesar.
- Titinius, finding him dead, takes his own life.
- Brutus calls Cassius 'the last of all the Romans' and says Caesar's spirit is mighty.

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CHAPTER · JULIUS CAESAR

Act V, Scene 4: Young Cato and Lucilius

A short scene of courage and a clever trick. Two men give everything for Brutus, and Antony shows that he can recognise honour.



IN THIS CHAPTER

- Another part of the field
- Cato's death
- Lucilius' trick
- Antony's mercy

Setting and Who Is On Stage

Another part of the battlefield. Fighting is going on. Present: Brutus, Messala, young Cato, Lucilius, Flavius, soldiers; then Antony and his men.

Scene Summary

Brutus rallies his men: 'Yet, countrymen, O, yet hold up your heads!' Young Cato, son of Marcus Cato and Brutus' brother-in-law, shouts his name across the field and fights bravely until he is killed. Lucilius sees the enemy soldiers close in and pretends to be Brutus: 'I am Brutus, Marcus Brutus, I.' He hopes they will take him and let the real Brutus escape.

Enemy soldiers capture him and run to tell Antony. Antony arrives and Lucilius offers himself for death, saying that Brutus will never be taken alive. Antony sees through the trick, and instead of punishing Lucilius, he praises his loyalty: 'I had rather have Such men my friends than enemies.' He orders him treated kindly and sends men to find Brutus, alive or dead.

Key Speeches Explained

Young Cato

He cries out his name in the thick of the fight: 'I am the son of Marcus Cato, ho! A foe to tyrants, and my country's friend.' Dying for the cause, he shows that the Republic is still worth fighting for. The scene links to Brutus' own family and Roman honour.

Lucilius' sacrifice

His false claim to be Brutus is a gift of time: if the enemy believes Brutus is captured, they may stop searching. When Antony spots the trick, he rewards loyalty. It is an unusual moment of kindness in a war of revenge. Antony's mercy contrasts with the death lists in IV.1 and prepares for his tribute to Brutus in V.5.

Quotes to Remember

QUOTE	SPEAKER	WHAT IT TELLS US
'Yet, countrymen, O, yet hold up your heads!'	Brutus	He encourages his army when they are losing.
'A foe to tyrants, and my country's friend'	Young Cato	His claim to be on the side of liberty.
'I am Brutus, Marcus Brutus, I'	Lucilius	A deliberate lie to protect the real Brutus.
'This is not Brutus, friend'	Antony	He sees the trick and honours it.
'I had rather have such men my friends than enemies'	Antony	A generous thought about loyalty.

Glossary

WORD OR PHRASE	MEANING
Bastard	Here, a coward or someone of base character
Proclaim my name	Call out my identity for all to hear
Straight	Immediately
Prize	A valuable captive

Context Questions with Model Answers

Extract 1



KEY POINT

'Brutus, my country's friend; know me for Brutus!'

(a) Who is speaking, and what is the situation?
Lucilius, in the middle of battle, after young Cato has fallen.

(b) Is he really Brutus?
No. He is pretending to be Brutus so the enemy will think they have captured him.

(c) Why does he do this?
To give the real Brutus time to escape.

(d) How does Antony react?
He is not angry. He says 'This is not Brutus, friend' but praises Lucilius' loyalty and orders that he be kept safe.

HOT Questions



HOT QUESTION

Why does Shakespeare show Antony in a kind light at this moment?
Think about: Respect for honour, a change from the death list, setting up the tribute to Brutus.

Quick Recap

- Young Cato dies fighting, proclaiming his name.
- Lucilius pretends to be Brutus to protect him.
- Antony recognises the lie and rewards Lucilius' faithfulness.

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CHAPTER · JULIUS CAESAR

Act V, Scene 5: The Death of Brutus

The play ends where it began: with Caesar's spirit satisfied. Brutus dies on his own sword, and Antony pays him a tribute that is remembered by every ICSE student.



IN THIS CHAPTER

- A rocky place
- Brutus asks his friends
- Strato's sword
- Antony's tribute
- Order restored

Setting and Who Is On Stage

Another part of the field, near a rocky hill. Brutus is exhausted and has only a few friends left: Clitus, Dardanius, Volumnius and Strato (the soldier Statilius, sent to scout, is spoken of but never returns). At the end, Antony, Octavius, Messala and Lucilius enter.

Scene Summary

Brutus, resting on a rock, asks Clitus, Dardanius and Volumnius in turn to help him end his life. Each refuses with tears. He tells Volumnius that Caesar's ghost has appeared to him twice, once at Sardis and once the night before at Philippi, and that his time has come. He says it is better to jump into the pit than wait to be pushed. Statilius, sent to see whether the camp is safe, has not returned, which Brutus takes as proof that he is dead.

As the enemy approaches, Brutus bids his friends goodbye. He says he has never had a friend who was not true to him, and that he will 'have glory by this losing day' more than Octavius and Antony will by their 'vile conquest'. Only Strato remains. Brutus asks him to hold the sword. He runs onto it, saying, 'Caesar, now be still; I kill'd not thee with half so good a will.'

Octavius, Antony, Messala and Lucilius arrive. Strato says that Brutus has died by his own hand and that 'Brutus only overcame himself'. Octavius takes Brutus' servants into his service. Antony delivers the closing tribute: of all the conspirators only Brutus acted from honest motives for the common good. 'This was the noblest Roman of them all.' Octavius orders full honours and the play ends with a call to rest the field.

Key Speeches Explained

The ghost and the pit

Brutus tells Volumnius of the ghost, which he sees as a signal that his hour has come. He says the enemy has driven them to the pit's edge and it is more honourable to leap in than be pushed. His acceptance of death is calm and consistent with Roman Stoic ideas.

Last words: 'Caesar, now be still'

He says he did not kill Caesar with as much willingness as he now kills himself. The line is complex: it admits that the murder was painful, and presents his death as justice. It matches the ghost's promise at Philippi and closes the circle begun in III.1.

Antony's tribute

Antony says that every other conspirator acted out of envy of Caesar, but Brutus alone joined 'in a general honest thought And common good to all'. Then comes the image of the ideal man: 'His life was gentle, and the elements So mix'd in him that Nature might stand up And say to all the world, "This was a man!"' The elements were the four humours (earth, air, fire, water) believed to make a person's character. In Brutus they were perfectly balanced. Antony, who earlier called Brutus 'honourable' with sarcasm, now says it with sincerity. Octavius adds that Brutus' body will lie in his own tent that night and be given full rites of burial.

Quotes to Remember

QUOTE	SPEAKER	WHAT IT TELLS US
'Caesar, now be still: I kill'd not thee with half so good a will'	Brutus	His last words; he dies by his own sword.
'Our enemies have beat us to the pit'	Brutus	Defeat is certain; better to choose one's death.
'I shall have glory by this losing day'	Brutus	He believes his honour outweighs the victors' success.
'Brutus only overcame himself'	Strato	Brutus was beaten by no one else.
'This was the noblest Roman of them all'	Antony	The most famous tribute in the play.
'This was a man!'	Antony	Nature would proudly point to Brutus.
'In a general honest thought And common good to all'	Antony	Brutus' motive was the public good, unlike the others.

Glossary

WORD OR PHRASE	MEANING
Pit	Trap; here a hunters' pit for animals, meaning the enemy's trap
Vile conquest	A shameful or unworthy victory
Envy	Resentful jealousy
Elements	The four elements (earth, air, fire, water) that made up the body and temperament
Gentle	Noble and kindly
Strato	Brutus' faithful servant who holds the sword
Entertain / prefer	Octavius takes Brutus' men into service
Rites of burial	Funeral ceremonies

Context Questions with Model Answers

Extract 1



KEY POINT

'This was the noblest Roman of them all: All the conspirators, save only he, Did that they did in envy of great Caesar.'

(a) Who speaks and where?
Antony, over Brutus' body at Philippi.

(b) What reason does Antony give for the other conspirators' acts?
They envied Caesar; they killed him out of jealousy.

(c) What was Brutus' motive, according to Antony?
A 'general honest thought and common good to all'; he truly believed he was saving Rome.

(d) Does this contradict Antony's earlier speech?
In III.2 he used 'honourable' mockingly. Now he means it. It shows that his grief and anger have passed and that he can recognise honest motives, even in an enemy.

Extract 2

KEY POINT
'Our enemies have beat us to the pit: It is more worthy to leap in ourselves Than tarry till they push us.'

(a) Who is speaking, and to whom?
Brutus, to Volumnius near the end of the battle.

(b) What does 'the pit' mean?
A trap into which hunted animals are driven; the point of no escape.

(c) What does he decide?
To take his own life rather than be captured.

(d) How does he view his death?
As more honourable than surrender, and as a debt owed to Caesar's ghost.

HOT Questions

HOT QUESTION
Is Antony's final tribute to Brutus sincere? Support your answer.
Think about: Contrast with III.2, 'honourable' sincere now, Strato's words.

HOT QUESTION
Why does Shakespeare end the play with Brutus, not with Antony or Octavius?
Think about: Tragic hero, honour, the order of the new Rome.

HOT QUESTION
Explain how Caesar's ghost is a link between Acts III and V.
Think about: Murder, revenge, 'Caesar, now be still', fate.

Quick Recap

- Brutus asks friends to kill him; they refuse, but Strato holds the sword.
- He dies saying, 'Caesar, now be still'.

- Antony calls him 'the noblest Roman of them all'.
- Octavius grants full burial honours and takes charge of Rome.

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CHAPTER · JULIUS CAESAR

Characters I: Caesar, Brutus, Cassius, Antony

Four men carry the play. For each one you need strengths, flaws, key moments and a quote or two.



IN THIS CHAPTER

- Julius Caesar
- Marcus Brutus
- Caius Cassius
- Mark Antony

Julius Caesar

The title character appears in only three scenes and dies in the middle of Act III, but his name or spirit is in nearly every scene after that. In the first half he is a great general, wise enough to see danger in Cassius, and a ruler who refuses the crown in public. He is also vain, superstitious, hard of hearing in one ear, subject to fits and over-confident.

- **Strengths:** courage, authority, shrewd reading of men ('he thinks too much: such men are dangerous'), generosity to the poor.
- **Flaws:** pride (he refers to himself in the third person, as 'Caesar'), love of flattery (Decius wins him by it), ignoring omens and warnings.
- **Key moments:** refusing Metellus' petition, 'constant as the northern star', and his dying 'Et tu, Brute?'.
- **After death:** his ghost, his will and the revenge motif keep him present.

Marcus Brutus

The tragic hero. A respected Roman, beloved by the people, devoted to the republic and to philosophy. He is Caesar's friend but is persuaded that Caesar must die for the good of Rome. His fault is naive idealism: he believes that others are as honest as he is.

- **Strengths:** honesty, self-control, deep love for Rome, kindness towards Lucius and Portia, loyal friend.
- **Flaws:** poor judgement of people (trusts Antony, rejects Cassius' advice), self-righteousness in the quarrel, rigid belief in principle.
- **Key moments:** the orchard soliloquy, the funeral speech, the quarrel with Cassius, the ghost, and his death.
- **Audience view:** Antony calls him 'the noblest Roman of them all'. Shakespeare invites sympathy but also shows that honourable motives can produce disastrous decisions.

Caius Cassius

The planner. Thin, intense and sharp-witted, Cassius organises the conspiracy and recruits Brutus. His motives are mixed: he resents Caesar's greatness ('he doth bestride the narrow world like a Colossus') and admires Brutus. He is more realistic than Brutus but less trusted by the public.

- **Strengths:** political cunning, military experience, deep love for Brutus, readiness to admit he is wrong.
- **Flaws:** envy, hot temper, accepting bribes, and a tendency to despair, which leads him to a needless suicide.
- **Key moments:** the forged letters, warnings about Antony, the dagger in IV.3, and his death with Caesar's sword.
- **Contrast with Brutus:** Cassius understands people but lacks moral authority; Brutus has authority but misreads people.

Mark Antony

Seen first as a cheerful sportsman and devoted friend of Caesar, Antony grows into a clever, ruthless politician. He hides his grief, wins the conspirators' trust, and uses the funeral oration to turn Rome against them. In Act IV he is a triumvir who strikes names from lists, and in Act V he finishes as a generous victor.

- **Strengths:** eloquence, loyalty, presence of mind, ability to read a crowd.
- **Flaws:** ruthless ambition, manipulates people, willing to use violence, contempt for Lepidus.
- **Key moments:** the soliloquy over the body, the funeral speech, 'the dogs of war', the death list and the tribute to Brutus.
- **Reading:** hero or villain? Both views can be argued. Arguing both sides earns marks in long answers.

CHARACTER	IN ONE PHRASE	FATAL WEAKNESS	BEST QUOTE ABOUT HIM
Caesar	Great man, blind pride	Vanity	'I am constant as the northern star' (Caesar)
Brutus	Honest idealist	Misjudges others	'This was the noblest Roman of them all' (Antony)
Cassius	Clever schemer	Envy and despair	'The last of all the Romans' (Brutus)
Antony	Brilliant manipulator	Cold ambition	'Mischief, thou art afoot' (Antony)



SIDEKICK TIP

Always back a trait with a **scene and a short quote**. 'Brutus is honest' earns little. 'Brutus is honest: he refuses to take bribes and says he would rather coin his heart than raise money by vile means (IV.3)' earns full marks.



HOT QUESTION

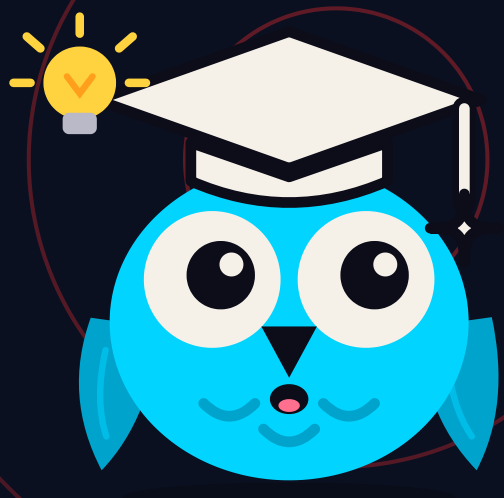
HOT: Is Brutus' decision to let Antony speak a sign of nobility or of poor judgement? Write a balanced paragraph.
Think about: his trust in honour versus Cassius' warning.

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CHAPTER · JULIUS CAESAR

Characters II: Portia, Calpurnia, Octavius and Others

Three important characters who appear briefly, and a few minor figures you should recognise.



IN THIS CHAPTER

- Portia
- Calpurnia
- Octavius
- Minor characters

Portia

Brutus' wife and Cato's daughter. She is intelligent, loving and brave. She wounds her own thigh to prove that she can keep a secret, then begs to be told what is troubling her husband. Her fear for Brutus, and the news that Octavius and Antony are growing stronger, drive her to take her own life by swallowing fire.

- **Role:** shows the human cost of the conspiracy and Brutus' tenderness.
- **Key lines:** 'I grant I am a woman; but withal a woman that Lord Brutus took to wife' (II.1).
- **Her death** is reported in IV.3 and explains Brutus' grief.

Calpurnia

Caesar's wife. She has a terrible dream in which Caesar's statue pours blood, and she tries to keep him from going to the Senate. She is not a superstitious woman by habit; she says 'Caesar, I never stood on ceremonies, Yet now they fright me.' She stands for the warnings Caesar ignores.

- Her speech: 'When beggars die, there are no comets seen; The heavens themselves blaze forth the death of princes.'
- Her failure to stop him shows how pride overcomes love and sense.

Octavius

Caesar's great-nephew and heir, young but self-assured. He joins Antony and Lepidus to avenge Caesar. At Philippi he insists on his own place in the line against Antony's wishes, and in the parley he declares he will not sheathe his sword until Caesar's murder is avenged. He closes the play by ordering Brutus' burial with honour and calling the field to rest.

- **Key lines:** 'I was not born to die on Brutus' sword' (V.1).
- **Role:** the new order that will replace the republic; he is the first emperor, Augustus, in later history.

Minor Characters

NAME	WHO THEY ARE	WHY THEY MATTER
Casca	Conspirator	Strikes the first blow; his blunt prose reports the crown scene.
Decius Brutus	Conspirator	Persuades Caesar to leave home by flattery.
Metellus Cimber	Conspirator	Begs Caesar to recall his brother Publius; the petition is the signal.
Trebonius	Conspirator	Leads Antony away from Caesar.
Cinna	Conspirator	Cries 'Liberty! Freedom! Tyranny is dead!'
Cinna the poet	A harmless poet	Killed by the mob by mistake.
Lepidus	Triumvir	A weak third partner who is dismissed by Antony.
Artemidorus	Teacher of rhetoric	Offers a letter to warn Caesar; Caesar ignores it.
Lucilius, Titinius, Messala	Officers	Loyal friends of Brutus and Cassius.
Pindarus	Cassius' bondman	Kills Cassius after misreading the field.
Lucius, Strato	Brutus' servants	Lucius plays music in IV.3; Strato holds the sword.
Young Cato	Portia's brother	Dies fighting at Philippi.



KEY POINT

Women in the play: only two, and both appear briefly. Both love their husbands and foresee danger. Both are overruled or kept in the dark, and both are right. Examiners sometimes ask you to compare them.



HOT QUESTION

HOT: Compare Portia and Calpurnia as wives. How does each try to protect her husband?
Think about: Portia's thigh wound and her plea for trust; Calpurnia's dream and her plea to stay at home.

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CHAPTER · JULIUS CAESAR

Themes in the Play

Five big ideas run through all three acts. Learn each with at least two scenes as proof.



IN THIS CHAPTER

- Power and ambition
- Honour
- Friendship and betrayal
- Fate and free will
- Rhetoric

1. Power and Ambition

The whole plot begins with a question: will Caesar become a king? The conspirators claim they kill him to prevent tyranny. Yet Cassius envies him, and the winners (Antony, Octavius, Lepidus) are soon dividing power and listing enemies for death. Shakespeare suggests that the desire for power is not limited to Caesar.

- III.1: Caesar compares himself with the northern star.
- III.2: Antony argues that Caesar refused the crown three times.
- IV.1: the triumvirs strike names from a list and share the world.

2. Honour

Roman honour means acting for the public good, keeping one's word, and dying rather than being disgraced. Brutus is its champion: 'Not that I loved Caesar less, but that I loved Rome more.' But the play also shows how honour can be abused. Antony repeats 'honourable man' until it becomes an insult, and Brutus' honour makes him trust the wrong people.

- IV.3: Brutus condemns Cassius' bribery.
- V.3: Titinius' suicide as 'a Roman's part'.
- V.5: Antony's tribute proves honour is recognised even by enemies.

3. Friendship and Betrayal

Caesar's last words, 'Et tu, Brute?', put betrayal at the centre. But the play also shows loyal friendships: Brutus and Cassius, Titinius and Cassius, Lucilius and Brutus. The quarrel in IV.3 shows how fragile friendship can be, and the reconciliation shows how strong.

4. Fate and Free Will

Omens fill the play: the soothsayer, the storm, Calpurnia's dream, the ghost, the eagles at Philippi. Characters read them differently. Cassius (an Epicurean) at first mocks omens, Caesar says 'what can be avoided whose end is purposed by the mighty gods?'. Yet the characters' decisions are their own: Caesar chooses to go to the Senate; Brutus chooses to attack early. Shakespeare leaves the question open.

- Cassius: 'The fault, dear Brutus, is not in our stars, but in ourselves' (I.2).
- Caesar: 'Cowards die many times before their deaths' (II.2).

5. Rhetoric and Persuasion

Words are weapons. Cassius persuades Brutus with flattery and forged letters; Decius persuades Caesar with flattery; Brutus persuades the crowd with logic, and Antony reverses it with emotion. In this play, whoever speaks last, and speaks best, wins.

THEME	BEST SCENES	ONE QUOTE
Power and ambition	III.1, IV.1	'I am constant as the northern star'
Honour	IV.3, V.5	'This was the noblest Roman of them all'
Friendship and betrayal	III.1, IV.3, V.3	'Et tu, Brute?'
Fate and free will	IV.3, V.1, V.3	'O Julius Caesar, thou art mighty yet!'
Rhetoric	III.2	'Friends, Romans, countrymen, lend me your ears'



HOT QUESTION

HOT: Can the play be called a tragedy of Brutus rather than Caesar? Give reasons.
Think about: who appears most, who makes the key choices, who dies last.

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CHAPTER · JULIUS CAESAR

Literary Devices and Language

Spot the device, name it, quote it and say what it does. That is how you earn marks in a language question.



IN THIS CHAPTER

- Dramatic irony
- Soliloquy
- Foreshadowing
- Rhetoric
- Imagery
- Blank verse

DEVICE	WHAT IT IS	EXAMPLE IN ACTS III TO V	EFFECT
Dramatic irony	The audience knows more than the characters	Caesar says he is 'constant' and is stabbed seconds later; Brutus trusts Antony	Creates tension and pity
Soliloquy	A character speaks thoughts aloud, alone	Antony over Caesar's body ('O, pardon me, thou bleeding piece of earth')	Reveals the true feeling behind a public mask
Foreshadowing	Hints at what will come	'Cry Havoc!'; the ghost's 'at Philippi'; Cassius' birthday	Builds fate and suspense
Irony (verbal)	Saying the opposite of what is meant	'Brutus is an honourable man'	Mocks and persuades
Repetition	A phrase used again and again	'Honourable man'; 'Tear him'	Drives a point home
Rhetorical question	A question asked for effect	'Who is here so base that would be a bondman?'	Pressures the listener to agree
Antithesis	Balanced opposites	'Not that I loved Caesar less, but that I loved Rome more'	Gives weight and logic
Personification	Giving human qualities to things	'Mischief, thou art afoot'; 'O hateful error, melancholy's child'	Makes abstract ideas alive
Metaphor and simile	Imagery by comparison	Lepidus as a horse; threats as 'idle wind'; 'dogs of war'	Vivid pictures
Pun / wordplay	Double meaning	'Tear him for his bad verses'	Dark humour
Allusion	Reference to a known person or story	Cato, Epicurus, the Nervii, Ate	Adds depth and Roman setting

Blank Verse and Prose

Most of the play is in **blank verse**: unrhymed lines of ten syllables with five stresses (iambic pentameter). For example, 'I come to bury Caesar, not to praise him.' Prose is used for ordinary citizens (the mob in III.3) and, notably, for **Brutus' funeral speech**, which sounds plain and logical. Antony's speech in verse sounds richer and more emotional. Rhymed couplets often end a scene to give a sense of closure.



SIDEKICK TIP

A neat exam point: 'Brutus speaks in prose to sound straight and honest, but Antony's poetic verse stirs the audience's feelings. Verse wins.'

Imagery

- **Blood:** hands bathed in Caesar's blood, the mantle, 'a tongue in every wound'. Blood stands for guilt and for revenge.
- **Animals:** dogs of war, horses, a dog baying at the moon, stag (hart). They show people being hunted or controlled.
- **Weather and sky:** storm, comets, the northern star, 'the sun of Rome is set'. These show nature's reaction to human events.
- **Theatre:** 'How many ages hence shall this our lofty scene be acted over'. The characters know they are making history.

Tone of Speeches

- Brutus: calm, balanced, formal.
- Antony: restrained at first, then fiery.
- Cassius: sharp, quick, persuasive, passionate in the quarrel.
- Caesar: confident, regal, speaks of himself as 'Caesar'.



KEY POINT

Remember: in any 'device' question, give **name + quote + effect**. Never only name the device.



HOT QUESTION

HOT: How does the shift from prose to verse in III.2 shape the audience's response to the two speeches?
Think about: plain logic vs emotional appeal.

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CHAPTER · JULIUS CAESAR

Answer-Writing Guide

You know the play. Now turn that knowledge into marks. This chapter shows the shape of each kind of answer.



IN THIS CHAPTER

- Context questions
- Character questions
- Long answers
- Common mistakes

What the Paper Looks Like

In the Literature paper, the drama section has questions on Julius Caesar based on the prescribed Acts. A typical set gives you an extract of a few lines followed by short questions worth about 3 to 4 marks each, then a longer essay-style question. Read the latest specimen paper and your school's guidance for the exact pattern.

1. Context (Extract) Questions

1. Who and where
Name the speaker and listener, the scene and the situation, in one sentence. 'Antony says this to the crowd in the Forum after Brutus' speech.'

2. Meaning
Explain the difficult word or line in simple language. Do not copy the line back.

3. Reason
Say why the speaker says it. Give the motive or the effect.

4. What it shows
Link to character, theme or later event. One quote is enough.



KEY POINT

Rule: one mark, one clear point. A 3-mark answer needs about 3 sentences, each making a different point.

2. Character Questions

Use the **PEE** pattern: **Point** (the trait), **Evidence** (a short quote or event), **Explanation** (what it shows and how it matters). Include at least one strength and one flaw for tragic figures like Brutus or Cassius.

WEAK	STRONG
Brutus is honest.	Brutus is honest: he rejects Cassius' bribery and says he would rather 'coin my heart' than raise money by 'vile means'. This honesty makes him a leader but also blinds him to Antony's tricks.
Antony is clever.	Antony is clever: by repeating 'Brutus is an honourable man', he turns praise into doubt, and persuades the crowd without openly breaking his promise.

3. Long Answers

1. Introduction
Answer the question directly in one or two sentences. Do not retell the plot.

2. Three body paragraphs
Each has one idea, one scene reference and a short quote.

3. Counter-view (if useful)
Mention the other side briefly. This shows depth.

4. Conclusion
Return to the question and give a final judgement.

Sample outline: 'How does Antony win over the crowd?' Intro: by using irony, evidence and emotion. Body 1: repeated 'honourable man'. Body 2: the will and the mantle. Body 3: the wounds speak. Conclusion: Antony wins because he lets the crowd feel it is their own idea.

Common Mistakes to Avoid

- Mixing up speakers (Casca strikes first; Brutus last; Antony speaks the 'dogs of war' lines).
- Misquoting. If unsure, paraphrase and use a short quote you are sure of.
- Narrating the story instead of answering the question.
- Forgetting the setting and the reason in extract answers.
- Calling a character simply good or evil. Shakespeare gives them depth.

Quick Revision Checklist

- Can I give the order of events in III.1 and V.3?
- Can I say who speaks the 'Et tu, Brute?', 'honourable man' and 'noblest Roman' lines?
- Do I have two quotes for each main character?
- Can I name three devices with an example each?
- Do I know why Brutus' speech fails and Antony's wins?



SIDEKICK TIP

In the last ten minutes of revision, read the quotes table in each scene chapter aloud. The wording is short on purpose so that it sticks.

Done reading? Now go break the board.



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